

physical activities that strengthen their muscles and coordination.

2. **Sleep disruption:** The blue light emitted from screens has been found to disrupt sleep patterns, especially in children. Blue light suppresses melatonin, the hormone responsible for sleep, making it harder for kids to fall asleep at night. Studies indicate that children with higher screen time, particularly before bed, tend to have shorter sleep duration and poorer sleep quality.

Inadequate sleep can then lead to issues such as reduced concentration, irritability, and impaired cognitive function. For children who are still in critical developmental stages, poor sleep can impact memory formation, learning abilities, and even emotional resilience.

3. **Impact on mental health:** Prolonged screen time, especially on social media, has been linked to issues such as anxiety, depression, and a decreased sense of well-being in older children and teenagers. The constant comparison, exposure to idealised images, and pressure to be “liked” can lead to self-esteem issues, even in young children. Online bullying and unrealistic portrayals on social media can amplify these effects, making children feel isolated or inadequate. Moreover, for younger kids, screen time can become an easy escape from boredom or emotional discomfort, which may hamper their ability to self-regulate emotions. Over time, this reliance on screens for comfort can lead to increased anxiety and an inability to cope with real-life challenges.

4. **Cognitive and behavioural changes:** Studies have shown that prolonged exposure to screens can influence brain development in young children. Excessive screen time has been linked to attention issues, impulsive behaviour, and difficulty with problem-solving and creativity. Younger children are particularly susceptible, as their brains are highly



plastic and influenced by stimuli from their environment.

Additionally, there is a growing concern that screen time can impact language development. While some digital content is educational, passively consuming videos and apps does not offer the same linguistic benefits as face-to-face interactions. This is especially true for toddlers.

How much screen time is healthy for kids?

Guidelines on screen time vary by age and purpose, but here's a general framework based on expert recommendations:

- **Under 18 months:** No screen time is recommended except for video calls, which allow social interaction with family and friends.
- **18 months to 2 years:** If screen time is introduced, it should be limited to high-quality, educational content with parental guidance.
- **3 to 5 years:** Limit screen time to one hour per day of high-quality content, co-viewed with a parent or caregiver to help interpret and apply learning.
- **6 years and older:** Set consistent limits on screen time based on family priorities and the child's needs. Experts generally advise a maximum of two hours of recreational screen time per day for school-aged children.

Note: This is not medical advice but the author's interpretation of studies and research articles that indicate the advised screen time for kids.

Managing screen time effectively

With screens embedded into everyday life, outright bans are neither practical

nor beneficial. Instead, parents can implement some really effective yet simple strategies and daily habits for their kids to foster a balanced relationship with technology.

1. **Establish “tech-free” zones:** Designate certain areas in the house, like the dining room or bedrooms, as screen-free zones. This practice encourages family bonding during meals and promotes a more restful environment for sleep.
2. **Model healthy screen habits:** Children learn by observing adults. If parents set limits on their own screen time, use devices purposefully, and spend time away from screens, children are more likely to emulate these behaviours.
3. **Encourage alternative activities:** Introduce children to non-screen-based activities that they can engage in regularly, such as outdoor play, reading, art, or family games. Activities that stimulate creativity and physical movement can naturally reduce screen time.
4. **Create a schedule:** Setting a routine with designated times for screen use can help manage children's screen habits. Allocating specific times for screen use, schoolwork, physical activity, and family time allows children to experience a well-rounded day.
5. **Use Parental Controls wisely:** Today's devices come with features that allow parents to set time limits on app usage or restrict access to certain types of content. This can be useful in preventing younger kids from spending excessive time on non-educational apps or social media.
6. **Encourage co-viewing and discussing content:** Co-viewing content with children not only helps monitor what they're watching but also opens opportunities for conversations. Discussing the content allows children to ask questions, understand concepts better, and develop critical thinking skills.

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